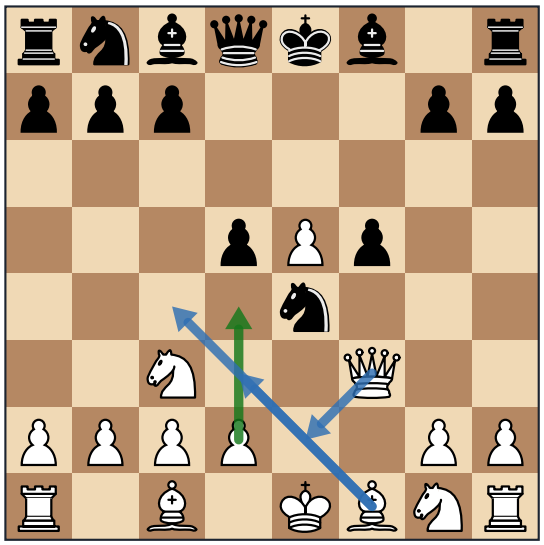
Vienna Game

ECO C25-C29 | 41 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3 f5

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.28** (slightly better for Black, depth 16). Best: d4.

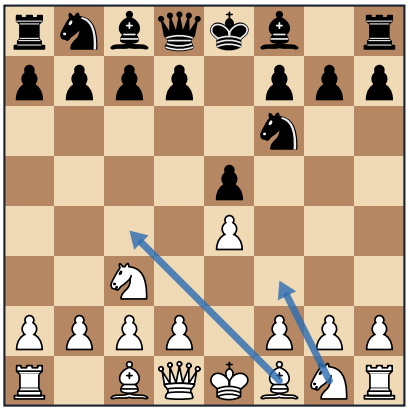
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3 f5

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
2... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.
3. f4	Attack the center. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3... d5	Free the position. Occupies the center with a pawn.
4. fxe5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
4... Nxe4	Captures on e4 to trade or win material.
5. Qf3	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
5... f5	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6



After f6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

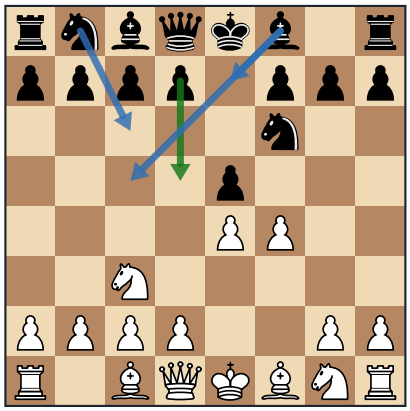


Position after the line

Stanley Variation C26 | 9 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4`

Stockfish: **+0.00** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Nc6.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Meitner-Mieses Gambit, Eifel Gambit, Reversed Spanish, Alekhine Variation

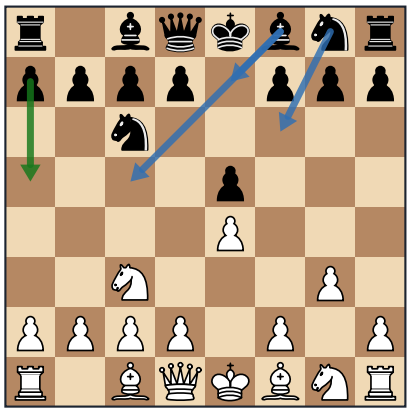


Position after the line

Vienna Gambit C29 | 9 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4`

Stockfish: **-0.19** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Bardeleben Variation, Breyer Variation, Kaufmann Variation, Main Line



Position after the line

Paulsen Variation C25 | 4 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.g3`

Stockfish: **-0.04** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: a5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Mariotti Gambit, Pollock Gambit



Position after the line

Mieses Variation C26 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.g3`

Stockfish: **+0.09** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Erben Gambit

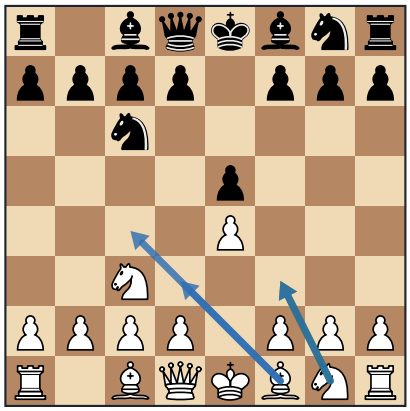


Position after the line

Anderssen Defense C25 | 1 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Bc5`

Stockfish: **+0.35** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)



Position after the line

Max Lange Defense C25 | 1 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6`

Stockfish: **+0.26** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)

Detailed repertoire notes

Vienna Game (C25-C29, White)

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Nf3 Be7 6.d4 O-O 7.Bd3 f5 8.exf6 Bxf6 9.O-O
```

Idea: Delay Nf3, play f4 when favorable and fight for e4 and the center.

Structure: Open or semi-open center with White space; king safety needs care after f4.

Pieces: Bc4/Bd3, Nf3, Qe2, long diagonal b2-g7 after d4. Knight c3 supports e4.

Plan: Develop, castle, strike with f4 or d4. In the Bc4 line Black may counter with ...Nxe4; know the tactics.

King: Castle before opening lines: f4 weakens your king. **Opponent:** ...d5 to hit e4 and the center for quick equality.

Watch out: Playing 3.Bc4 Nxe4 invites the Frankenstein-Dracula mess: study it or avoid.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Vienna Game (all lines)** C25
  `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3`
  - **Anderssen Defense** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bc5`
  - **Falkbeer Variation** C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6`
  - **Max Lange Defense** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6`
  - **Fyfe Gambit** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.d4`
  - **Giraffe Attack** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bc5 3.Qg4`
  - **Hamppe-Meitner Variation** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bc5 3.Na4`
  - **Mengarini Variation** C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.a3`
  - **Mieses Variation** C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.g3`
    - **Erben Gambit** C26
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.g3 -> 3...d5 4.exd5 c6`
  - **Omaha Gambit** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...d6 3.f4`
  - **Paulsen Variation** C25
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.g3`
    - **Mariotti Gambit** C25
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.g3 -> 3...Bc5 4.Bg2 h5 5.Nf3 h4`
    - **Pollock Gambit** C26
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.g3 Bc5 4.Bg2 Nc6 5.Nge2 d5 6.exd5`
  - **Stanley Variation** C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.Bc4`
    - **Reversed Spanish** C26
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 -> 3...Bb4`
    - **Three Knights Variation** C28
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6`
    - **Eifel Gambit** C26
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 -> 3...Bc5 4.Nge2 b5`
    - **Bronstein Gambit** C28
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.f4 Nxe4 5.Nf3`
    - **Meitner-Mieses Gambit** C25
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.Qg4 Qf6 5.Nd5`
    - **Monster Declined** C27
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Qh5 Nd6 5.Bb3 Be7`
    - **Alekhine Variation** C27
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Qh5 Nd6 5.Bb3 Be7 6.Nf3 Nc6 7.Nxe5`
    - **Frankenstein-Dracula Variation** C27
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Qh5 Nd6 5.Bb3 Nc6 6.Nb5 g6 7.Qf3 f5 8.Qd5 Qe7 9.Nxc7 Kd8 10.Nxa8 b6`
  - **Vienna Gambit** C29
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.f4`
    - **Main Line** C29
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5`
    - **Steinitz Variation** C29
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.d3`
    - **Modern Variation** C29
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.d3`
    - **Paulsen Attack** C29
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3`
    - **Bardeleben Variation** C29
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3 f5`

- **Breyer Variation** C29
  1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Nf3 Be7
- **Kaufmann Variation** C29
  1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Nf3 Bg4 6.Qe2
- **Wurzburger Trap** C29
  1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 -> 3...d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.d3 Qh4 6.g3 Nxg3 7.Nf3 Qh5 8.Nxd5

Frankenstein-Dracula Variation C27
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.Bc4 Nxe4

Philidor Countergambit C25
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.d4 f5

Zhuravlev Countergambit C25
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bb4 3.Qg4 Nf6

Adams' Gambit C27
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.Bc4 Nxe4 4.Qh5 Nd6 5.Bb3 Nc6 6.d4

Hamppe-Muzio Gambit C25
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.f4 exf4 4.Nf3 g5 5.Bc4 g4 6.O-O

Heyde Variation C29
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3 f5 6.d4

Hamppe-Muzio C25
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.f4 exf4 4.Nf3 g5 5.Bc4 g4 6.O-O gxf3 7.Qxf3 Ne5 8.Qxf4 Qf6

- **Dubois Variation** C25
  1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.f4 exf4 4.Nf3 g5 5.Bc4 g4 6.O-O gxf3 7.Qxf3 Ne5 8.Qxf4 Qf6

Pierce Gambit C25
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Nc6 3.f4 exf4 4.Nf3 g5 5.d4 g4 6.Bc4 gxf3 7.O-O d5 8.exd5 Bg4 9.dxc6

- **Rushmere Attack** C25
  1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.f4 exf4 4.Nf3 g5 5.d4 g4 6.Bc4 gxf3 7.O-O d5 8.exd5 Bg4 9.dxc6

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Qf3 f5
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.